

STICK IT
'Art stamps' of M.F. Husain, S.H. Raza, issued to mark the 1982 Festival of India

The festival opened in London in March 1982 with a series of shows by leading Indian performing artists and 19 exhibitions, ranging from *In the Image of Man* (a panorama of 2000 years of sculptural representations of humankind), installations on village life to a show on contemporary art featuring 133 pieces by some of the most prominent Indian modernists. Mrs Gandhi visited the British capital for the inauguration and lunched with the Queen and prime minister Margaret Thatcher. Despite scattered protests, particularly by Khalistan supporters, and some kvetching by critics at the 'elite extravaganzas', there was no disputing the popularity and prominence of the festival.



"The raison d'etre of the festival is to create something permanent, to reinforce the spirit of commerce"— RAJEEV SETHI, *Curator (1985)*

Later editions were staged on an even grander scale—notably the 1985 edition in the US, which was also a vehicle for new PM Rajiv Gandhi's international charm offensive. One of the highlights of this festival was the staging of Peter Brook's *The Mahabharata*, an event that remains emblematic of the style and aura of the Festival of India moment: an early rebranding of traditional Indian aesthetics, melding folk, classical and contemporary, and their marketing to a global audience. The festivals would also add a cosmopolitan-modernist gloss to Indian handicrafts in the domestic market, arguably igniting the appeal for a whole range of existing and yet unborn lifestyle products and brands. ■


Selling A Civilisation

FROM THE ARCHIVES
Apr. 15, 1982

Special Feature
Selling a Civilisation

Inside, the atmosphere belonged to another world altogether. Celebrities...congregated to listen to M.S. Subbalakshmi... A motley Indo-British crowd, the audience may not have been able to understand much of her music, but were only too eager to applaud...
–Bonny Mukherjee & Sunil Sethi



"I've always felt that if India has to project itself, it should project big or not at all. And that is not always a question of money..."

— PUPUL JAYAKAR, *Director, Festival of India (1982)*

DID YOU KNOW?

The 1982 FoI featured a commercial showcase at the London department store, Selfridges, which paired 'tacky treasures from the Maharaja of Jaipur's collections' (as an INDIA TODAY report put it) with herbal beauty products by Shahnaz Husain, Zodiac shirts and Nalini sarees

RISE OF ETHNIC CHIC

» The event rebranded India, quite literally, with a range of 'merch' bearing the 'FoI' logo. Later editions had freshly designed logos

» In the domestic market, this aesthetic would power a new boom in 'ethnic chic' through brands like Fabindia and Anokhi

» The rise of Indian 'Heritage Tourism', from the havelis of Shekhawat to the 'Palace on Wheels' and other tourist novelties, also owes something to the FoI's success